

alea's garden

1 player • 30 minutes
46 cards • 30 blue “water” cubes • 30 black “rot” cubes



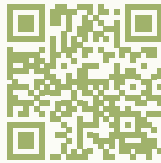
Alea's Garden is a cosy polyomino deckbuilding game, designed for the 2025 BoardGameGeek Solitaire competition! Balance beauty and decay within your garden in this pocket-sized card game for one player. Things aren't beautiful because they last forever.

Game Design: **Brave James**

Art & co-design: **Jon Tiburzi**

Cover art: **Georg Fischer**

How to play video: <https://linktr.ee/aleasgarden>



overview

Alea's Garden is a deckbuilding game: you upgrade and expand the cards in your deck to earn  (victory points). These cards arrange to form gardens, wherein you water plots to gain resources while managing a pervasive rot that covers plots. Some cards have special features, bringing your garden to life.

The game plays over 5 years (rounds), each containing three phases: an action phase, an upgrade phase, and a cleanup phase. Earn  25+ at the end of year 5 to win!

action phase

Choose the top card of either Action Deck pile. Perform all of its actions in order, from top to bottom (see page 2).

Repeat this process, choosing cards and performing actions, until you reach an action that cannot be fully performed. When this happens, remove all cubes from your garden and go to the next phase. If year 5, skip to the endgame.

setup

- 1 Shuffle the Starting Cards ($\times 8$), with  side down. Place under the Sun Card to form the Garden Deck.
- 2 Create your garden by drawing the bottom 5 cards from the Garden Deck, overlapping them to form a 5×4 grid.
- 3 Prepare “water” cubes ($\times 30$) and “rot” cubes ($\times 30$).
- 4 Align the Track Cards, and place tracker cubes on year 1 and the  and  starting points.
- 5 Shuffle the Expansion Deck ($\times 18$), with  side down.
- 6 Shuffle the Action Deck ($\times 16$), using both sides. Divide the deck into two similarly sized piles.

upgrade phase

Draw the top 3 cards of the Expansion Deck.

Spend gained  to perform any combination of the options listed below. The  cost is indicated in the bottom-left corner of each card. You may choose the same option several times.

Upgrade: choose one card in your garden and flip it over, which fortifies the plots and earns .

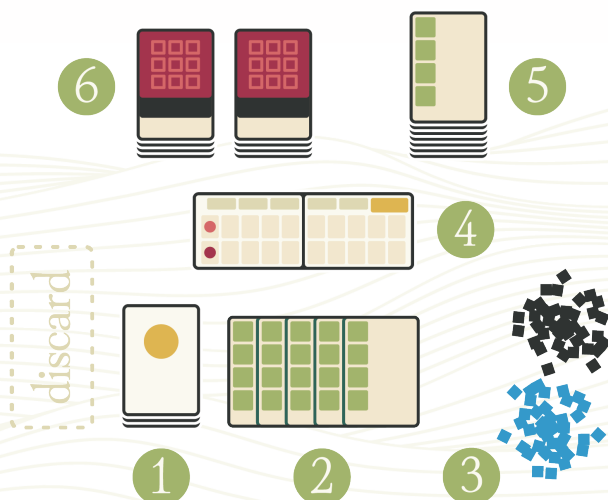
Expand: add one of the drawn Expansion Cards to your Garden Deck. Expansion Cards feature items with new, unique effects. See the appendix for a full list!

Expansion Cards are worth more .

Then, go to the next phase.

cleanup phase

Return any unused Expansion Cards to the bottom of the Expansion Deck. Reshuffle all discarded Action Cards back into the Action Deck, and divide into two equal piles. Reshuffle all Garden Cards back into the Garden Deck (maintaining orientation).



Reset the 🌸 and 🌞 tracks. Advance the year marker by 1.

Draw the bottom 5 Garden Cards to create a new garden; you may Replant.

Replant: Once at the start of each year, you may reshuffle all Garden Cards and recreate your garden.

Whenever you draw a card with + 📄 into your garden: Draw an additional card from the bottom of the Garden Deck, and add it to your garden by placing it alongside the garden's rightmost column.

Start the next year with the action phase.

endgame

Lay out all your Garden Cards. Spend gained 🌸 to upgrade however many cards. Then, add up all the 📄 indicated in the bottom-left corners of your Garden Cards. If your total is 📄 25+, you win!

actions

🚰 watering

Watering helps your garden flourish! Place water cubes onto unoccupied garden plots (the squares) in the pattern depicted on the Action Card. The pattern can be rotated or flipped (or both). See 1 and 3.

Unoccupied plots: Cubes cannot be placed on plots that already contain a cube. If a pattern cannot fit anywhere in your garden, the action cannot be performed; instead, immediately clear all cubes from your garden and go to the next phase.

Once all cubes are placed, each plot covered this way is now “watered”. Certain plots gain benefits when watered, which can be resolved in any order:

🚰 🌸 = gain +1 🌸

Watered blossom plots each gain 1 blossom. Use the Track Cards to record gained and spent 🌸 (no maximum: use additional cubes to track beyond 10).

🚰 🌞 = gain +1 🌞

Watered sunlight plots each gain 1 sunlight. Use the Track Cards to record gained 🌞 (maximum 10). For each milestone reached, gain +1 📄.

🚰 🌿 = gain +1 🌿

Watered pine trees each gain 1 resiliency. There is no Track Card for resiliency. Instead, each gained 🌿 decreases the amount of rot by 1 in the next action.

🦠 rot

Rot spreads across your garden, taking up precious space! Place the indicated number of rot cubes onto unoccupied garden plots – don't forget to decrease this amount by the resiliency (the number of 🌿) gained during the previous watering action. Resiliency can be freely split across any rot instances except those that are locked: 🔒.

Rot placement: Each instance of rot grows in a continuous shape, connecting to itself along one or more adjacent sides (not diagonally, unless stated otherwise). See 2.

If the rot cannot fit anywhere in your garden, immediately clear all cubes from your garden and go to the next phase.

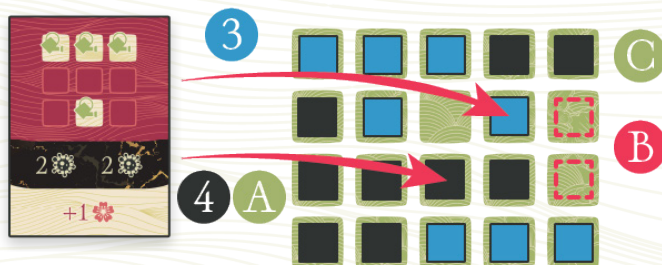
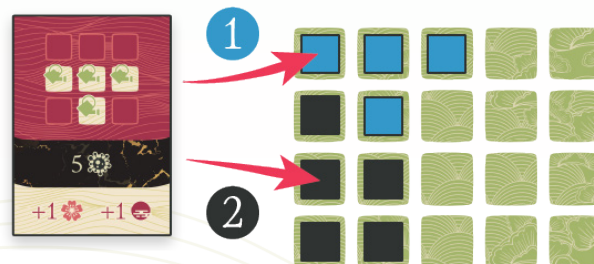
Some Action Cards have multiple rot instances. See 4. Separate rot instances placed during the same action cannot be adjacent: A is allowed, since the adjacent rot was placed on a previous action; B contacts A and so is not allowed, but C is allowed.

See the appendix for further explanations of icons.

If you run out of cubes, use a substitute.

bonus

Lastly, gain any extra 🌸 and 🌞, if listed.



appendix

— water-triggered effects —



golden plot

When watered: Gain +1 additional resource.
For example, 🌸 gains an additional +1 🌸.



mitsudomoe

When watered: Gain either +1 🌸, 🍵, or 🌿.



spring breeze

When watered: Gain a number of 🌸 equal to the number of rot cubes in its row.



bridge

When watered: Gain a number of 🌸 equal to the current milestone (1, 2, 3, or 4). Then, gain +2 🍵.



butterflies

When watered: In this same action, each watered 🌸 gains an additional +2 🌸.



dragonfly

When watered: In this same action, each watered 🟩 (empty regular plot) gains +1 🌸, and each watered 🟩 (empty upgraded plot) gains +2 🌸.



crane

When watered: In this same action, each watered 🌸 gains an additional +1 🌸, each watered 🍵 gains an additional +1 🍵, and each watered 🌿 gains an additional +1 🌿.



koi

When watered: In the next rot action, rot becomes water. Follow rot placement rules, but use water cubes instead of rot cubes. Gain any benefits of watering, such as gaining resources.



tea

Gain +3 🌸 and +1 🟩 immediately once both plots have been watered. This can be achieved across multiple actions.



— rot-triggered effects —



mushrooms

When covered by rot: Gain +2 🌸.



stone lantern

When covered by rot: At the end of this action, you may remove the rot cube from this plot. If you do, gain +1 🌸.



mist

When covered by rot: Remove a number of water cubes in your garden equal to the current milestone (1, 2, 3, or 4). Then, gain +2 🍵.

— ongoing effects —

If a cube is ever placed on a plot providing an ongoing effect, the ongoing effect is immediately deactivated.



raked sand

Each watered 🟩 also gains +1 🍵.



parasol

Each watered 🍵 nearby 🌂 (in the same column, and the neighboring left and right columns) gains an additional +1 🍵.



chidori

Each watered 🌿 nearby 🐦 (in the same column, and the neighboring left and right columns) also gains +1 🌸 and +1 🍵.



lotus

Once per action: Gain +2 🌸 if at least 2 🟩 plots are watered in the same action.



treasure knot

Once per action: Gain +2 🌸 if at least 1 🌸 plot, 1 🍵 plot, and 1 🌿 plot are watered in the same action.



garden extension

When you draw a card with this icon: Draw an additional card from the bottom of the Garden Deck, and add it to your garden by placing it alongside the garden's rightmost column.



advanced card

Cards with this icon are slightly more advanced and can be omitted for your first game.



coin

Earn these victory points by upgrading garden plots.

— action icons —



Place water cubes onto unoccupied garden plots in the depicted pattern. The pattern can be rotated or flipped (or both). Some patterns must be placed such that they cover a specified icon.



rot

Place rot cubes onto unoccupied garden plots, according to the rot placement rules.



locked rot

This rot cannot be reduced by resiliency (🌿).



covering rot

This rot instance must cover at least 1 🌸 plot.



connected diagonally

This rot instance follows different placement rules: it can only connect to itself along diagonal corners. Changing directions (zig-zag) is allowed.

milestone

The sunlight track (☀️) is divided into four milestones. Your marker position on the sunlight track also marks your current milestone. When you reach each milestone, gain +1 📊.

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